Barthes

Roland Barthes is one of the most important and influential of the contemporary French cultural critics. He died in 1980 but by the end of his career he had broken decisively with the most important traditions in post-World War II Western European thought, particularly structuralism and Marxism. The result of his investigations, which are organized around the theme of semiotics, the theory of signs, served to drive contemporary French culture, and perhaps Western high culture more broadly, towards poststructuralism and postmodernism.

This is Barthes' great achievement, bound up with his critical activities. His work offers one possible reading of Nietzsche. In fact Barthes' reading of Nietzsche, emphasizing aesthetics, a critical stance and the critic's outsider status, actually transforms the critic into a creative artist. In expanding the critic's domain and creativity, he creates a new sort of art form, or if not a new sort of art form, a new approach to human creativity which allows for the questioning of all previously established verities and allows for the undermining and interrogation of what postmodernists call foundational discourses.

Because Barthes was a French intellectual who was simultaneously Protestant, homosexual and without a doctorate, he was very much an outsider in the French academy. Illness had interrupted his studies when he was due to take his final examinations. He was unlike most French intellectuals, and personal issues may have helped drive his demythologizing project. They may have made him more sensitive to hidden coercions and hypocrisies in French intellectual culture, but particularly in French mass culture. He is remarkable for his sensitive and intelligent readings of mass culture and its artifacts.

He uses semiotics to decode the artifacts of mass culture to discern their hidden messages, who produces them, and for what purposes. These purposes are usually coercive, since he initially works within the Marxist tradition. His original aim in demythologizing, in finding hidden meanings within mass-cultural artifacts, is to liberate us from the tyranny of mass-produced consciousness. He wants to free us and perhaps enable us to become individuals. In *A Lover's Discourse: Fragments*, a lovely book halfway between novel and essay, he explains that he wrote it because the lover's discourse is one of profound loneliness and in fact Barthes is continuing a theme that was developed in the middle part of the 20th century in French culture, the idea of the lonely ego, existentially operating in a void of meaning, in a void of coherence, deciding arbitrarily how to arrange and fix the world, in a way almost constructing the world.

Barthes, like many French intellectuals, retreats into interiority, away from the external world, and suggests that the external world is constructed by us, not given to us. This is in some ways a derivation from the Kantian project of showing that we actively construct the external world, but it's much more radical than Kant's project because Barthes ultimately argues that we construct not just the world of signs, society and history, but nature itself as a social and linguistic construct. In a way you could say that he's formulating a sort of Cartesian aesthetics in which the lonely ego confronts a completely indeterminate world and the project is then interesting, creative, pleasurable world-making.

Barthes liberates the critic, the ego and the self from preconceived identities and from arbitrary and spurious limitations on human activity. One might say that Barthes created a poetic protest against human limitations and it's in the form of a demythologizing myth. Ironically, by the end of his project he goes so far in semiotic demythologizing that he turns reflexively upon structuralism, Marxism and semiotics itself, asking whether these too are myths with hidden agendas. The demythologizer ends by demythologizing demythology. The result is a meta-myth: instead of unmasking reality to reveal its true face, its underlying substantial reality, one discovers only another mask. There are masks all the way down. There's no face underneath it. There is no substantial reality. Barthes withdraws into interiority, into a very carefully and thoroughly cultivated self.

Barthes can be seen as the great philosophical exponent of pleasure and the pleasure principle in contemporary thought. The sort of person that moves away from the external world, tries to render it dubious, contingent, arbitrary, and dependent upon construction by the self, is the sort of person that feels oppressed by the external world and would like to remove all those limitations. One might say that Barthes' work in some respects represents the triumph of the pleasure principle over the reality principle.

He withdraws into his mind as the Epicurean withdraws into a pleasure garden. That is why one of his finest and latest works is called *The Pleasure of the Text*. What he has done by liberating us from authority and from the author and from any preconceived, predetermined meaning within a text is to say that we as critics, as careful readers of the text, have completely free play. Our domain is one of complete power and control. By withdrawing predetermined meaning, by killing off the author and saying that all we have is the text, Barthes makes the critic a creative artist. His writing is also enjoyable because he is such a wit.

He has a very morbid, sarcastic wit, and he's somewhat like Oscar Wilde in the sense that it's a kind of exercise in sarcasm, which is very arch and carefully drawn. A strength of French high culture has always been its powerful connection between philosophy and poetry. French philosophical thinkers, for the most part, are closely allied to poetic expression, poetic considerations, aesthetic considerations, and Barthes is one of the extreme examples of that tendency.

In a book called *Mythologies*, which was published in 1957, there is an ironic combination of Marxist cultural criticism, akin to that of the Frankfurt School, and the unmasking of mass communications such as advertising. These are presented as instruments of social control serving a small elite. Barthes is doing something like that in his *Mythologies*. It's a collection of short essays in which he examines various artifacts from French culture in the 1950s and demythologizes them. He distinguishes what an artifact appears to mean from a hidden second level of meaning that goes beyond it. He calls this second level myth. The collection concludes with the essay *Myth Today*, which belongs to the original book of 1957. His later reconsideration of demythologizing, notably in *Mythology Today* in 1971, raises the possibility that the project cannot achieve what it originally sought: perhaps there are masks all the way down. If there is no substantial reality behind appearance, the possibility of completely demythologizing the world disappears. There is only one myth after another. Examples of his critical activity clarify the argument.

Barthes practices semiotics, which can be defined as the science or theory of signs, the general science of signs envisaged by Saussure. It develops in connection with structural linguistics, founded and organized by Saussure around the turn of the twentieth century. Semiotics views the human domain as a domain of symbols and signs. It reads these signs and searches for their internal coherence, concentrating primarily on the coherence of relations between them. The relation between signs and the world is not mimetic, in the sense that it doesn't represent the world. Rather, the relationship between signs is semiotic. In other words, internal coherence of the system of symbols is what we're talking about, not the correspondence between the content of the symbols and the world.

It corresponds to a shift in the conception of truth. Semiotics holds to the idea of a coherence conception of truth. This resembles Rorty's position: if the symbol set is coherent, there is no external standard by which to judge it. We can't judge it by whether it reflects the world, because it is assumed at the outset that systems of symbols do not mimic the world, that mimesis is impossible. Rather, their truth is to be found in the internal coherence of the systems.

Consider non-Euclidean geometry. Its logical coherence can be assessed independently of whether a particular system is applied to the physical world. If correspondence with the world were the only standard, a system without a physical application might appear deficient. If truth is understood as coherence, however, it can be entirely satisfactory, just as Euclidean geometry is. Barthes adopts a set of assumptions roughly like this.

Psychoanalysis and Marxism are examples of separate, incommensurable semiotic systems. Clothing is another such system. Mass culture, including advertising or MTV, is a powerful semiotic system. Familiar examples show how semiotic analysis works; people perform it throughout their lives.

A sailor leaves a ship and comes into port. Two women greet him: “Hi, sailor.” One wears a long black dress and a crucifix around her neck; she is a nun. Her greeting simply says hello to the sailor. The other woman appears in red satin shorts and a transparent blouse. She also says: “Hi, sailor.” In this example, she is presented as a prostitute rather than a nun, and the greeting means something quite different in that semiotic system. Her clothing is a text that the sailor reads, which tells him not to proposition the nun. People do this all the time. In *The Fashion System*, Barthes analyzes women's fashion as a semiotic system. It is indeed a system of signs: a remarkable idea.

One advantage is that it can be applied to the entire human domain. Every kind of communicative activity and sign can be broken down and analyzed. We can find its first-order meaning, and then perhaps we could also find a second-order meaning. That second-order meaning, the underlying myth or hidden meaning, is the object of Barthes' project.

Barthes has a wonderful sense of humor, and he seems to be attracted to the bizarre and odd in the world. He approaches the world obliquely and ironically. It's strange that a highly cultivated, extremely sensitive French intellectual should write an essay on professional wrestling, on detergent, on striptease, on the brain of Einstein. Einstein's brain was removed after his death and preserved. Barthes considers it as a cultural icon,

asking what it means. He also reads plastic in this way. What does plastic mean? What's the myth hidden in it? You wouldn't have thought perhaps there was any myth hidden in it. In fact, this is Barthes' project, to go from surface structure to deep structure. When he reconsiders the project ten or fifteen years later, he finds only surface structures: he has merely moved from one surface to another.

His treatment of wrestling is worthwhile: even when he is not entirely accurate, he is entertaining and perceptive. Intellectuals tend to laugh at professional wrestling and look down on its audience, regarding it as childish. They dismiss it as silly, a pseudo-sport. Barthes offers a deeper reading: working-class people attend wrestling because it is a spectacle, not a sport. They're not stupid. The spectators know perfectly well that the contest is arranged. The question, then, is what they get out of it and why they attend. Barthes sees a communal spectacle whose outcome is already known. The spectators cheer symbols, or personifications of various cultural tendencies.

A later illustration would be Hulk Hogan appearing as an American hero, wearing the flag. The audience cheers for America, personified by the wrestler, and knows that he must win. This example extends the kind of reading Barthes offers.

The spectacle is not what it first appears to be. Looking backward, this reading relates wrestling to the origins of Attic drama. When tragedy started out, it was not high art. It was popular art, and everybody knew exactly what was going on, and the end was foretold. Something comparable occurs in *Oedipus* and, in a later setting, with Hulk Hogan. Oedipus is a symbol, not a person, and we all know the outcome of the story. Cheering creates a sense of social solidarity. He represents us.

This brings high art down to earth. Contemporary intellectuals regard tragedy as the highest art: what greater achievement of Attic culture is there than Oedipus? Yet, on this reading, tragedy originally resembled a spectacle like wrestling, though it has since been transformed. Ordinary people, the people in the street or the agora, attended knowing how the story had to end. The point is that it is a spectacle rather than a sport. Its story is predetermined, and it is a system of signs. Professional wrestling can be read. It is a text.

The discussion of detergents is also amusing. It is odd to imagine this cultivated intellectual treating the World Detergent Congress held in Paris in 1954, an unlikely setting for such a convention. Manufacturers presented advertisements for their various detergents, and Barthes examined these advertisements as texts. What do they tell us? For example, the claim that a detergent cleans linen deeply implies that linen has depth. What would it mean for linen to be deep? Barthes examines the carefully constructed distinctions between roughly equivalent products. One is green, the other is blue. Chemically, they may be completely identical. Only the coloring has changed, yet each has a different advertising campaign. One appeals to the man of the house, showing a lumberjack washing his hands with the blue product. Blue is masculine. If a woman washes dishes with a pink product, pink is feminine. Chemically, it may be completely identical, but what we are doing here is constructing a contemporary myth, and what Barthes is saying is that myth has become a commodity, and commodities have become myths. In a way, it's a change in the old Marxist formula, C-M-C, from *Capital*, Volume I: commodity, money, commodity.

The sequence becomes consumer goods, mythology, and more consumer goods. In this culture, consumer goods perform a function previously served by the transcendence of religious objects. In other words, we fetishize consumer goods, which is why we bow down before this year's new Cadillac and introduce it with a drumroll. The new Cadillac becomes an icon of contemporary life, ease and luxury. A Cadillac advertisement displays “Cadillac style.” What does that style mean? What is the myth implicit there? Rich people, happy people, people who have good lives have Cadillacs. To have a Cadillac is to have a good life. Cadillac means a good life. There are myths being constructed, and our new mythologizers are not Homer, are not Shakespeare, they are admen.

It is a deep and caustic argument. He investigates striptease, and he infers that the process of striptease desexualizes woman. Why? Because it never goes the entire way. It never turns into sex. It is an elaborate ritual offering a kind of catharsis for the sexual drives of men, who make up most of the audience. It is entirely stereotyped and could almost be reduced to a formula. He reads it as the construction of a myth of woman, particularly through the incompleteness of sexuality in the ritual.

In the fine short essay on Einstein's brain, the underlying myth is that knowledge is a formula. Knowledge appears to be enclosed within a physical space, contained in the brain: knowledge in a box. The implied message is that one day we shall know what makes this brain so great, but meanwhile we keep it in a container. Knowledge is in a box. Einstein's brain is the opposite of a postmodern icon. A postmodern gesture would be to destroy the brain and break the box.

That would be postmodernism. Finally, he reads plastic, an unexpected and even perverse idea. Barthes reads plastic, and what he finds underneath the plastic image is the myth of infinite transformation. You can turn plastic into anything. You can change its color. You can change its shape. It can be put to all kinds of uses. Plastic is the ultimate postmodern substance. Plastic signifies infinite freedom and transformation, in both the adjectival and noun senses of the word. This leads back to myth, particularly the concluding essay *Myth Today*.

What happens in myth? Myth is misleading because myth dissolves the realm of history by making it appear as nature. It makes the world appear natural and given. It disguises the message that is being proposed.

One of Barthes' most important examples, discussed endlessly in criticism of his work, is the photograph of a Black soldier. In a French magazine in the mid-1950s, he sees a Black soldier saluting the French tricolor. He wears a military uniform. At the first level, the sign is the piece of paper with its pattern of light and dark spots. That's what a photograph is, in a literal strict sense. What the sign signifies is the saluting Black soldier. That is the obvious surface meaning. But Barthes asks what the photograph means at a second level. Initially, the photograph relates to the image of the Black soldier as a sign relates to what it signifies. Semiotics investigates signs and their relations to what they signify.

The image of the soldier is itself placed in the position of a sign, signifying something at a second level. The analysis moves into a new level of meaning. Barthes argues that the photograph is an apology for French colonialism. Its implied message is that, despite the

breakdown of the French colonial empire, opposition to colonialism, and the racist and imperialist elements of French political life, there is no problem. The happy, contented, loyal and docile soldier saluting the tricolor supposedly demonstrates this. That is the message beneath the photograph. He regards modern cultural artifacts as working in this way, subjecting us to disguised coercion. It's a deep argument.

A later American analogy is *Rambo*. On one level, the film is a series of dots on a screen. It shows Sylvester Stallone killing hundreds of people, being the toughest and apparently invincible man. He's something like the modern Achilles. That's the first level. That's the obvious surface meaning. The second, mythological level claims that America did not lose the Vietnam War, but won it: withdrawal was strategic. The strategic retreat continues in artworks that imply there was no real problem. Its message is: “One American can kill five hundred opponents. We are the toughest people in the world. We never die, bleed or worry. We always get the job done.” In other words, the myth of American invincibility is built into the *Rambo* movies. It is impossible to miss. It obviously has ideological mythic content to it.

There may, however, be a plurality, perhaps an infinite plurality, of possible mythic readings. Once a text is entirely open and has no authority behind it, it can be treated and read in different ways. In some respects, Barthes gives with one hand and takes away with the other. He offers one reading but points out that it is not closed: infinitely many other readings are possible. Semiotics can therefore be called an open rather than a closed system. In this respect, it resembles Wittgensteinian language games.

There can be infinitely many overlapping games that do not necessarily conflict. A Freudian analysis of the American Civil War might claim, for example, that Abraham Lincoln freed the slaves because of his feelings about his father's authority. We also might want to do a Marxist analysis saying that the reason Lincoln freed the slaves is because he was the agent of advanced capitalism. The point that is made by Barthes is that semiotics tells us that these systems are not mutually exclusive. The same thing is being described under two different semiotic systems. Psychoanalysis does not refute a Marxist interpretation of history, and a Marxist interpretation does not refute psychoanalysis. They are different, incommensurable semiotic systems.

There is an infinite possible proliferation of semiotic systems so we get an infinitude of criticism and an infinitude of interpretation. In some ways you might say that Barthes' project is the inverse of that of Gadamer. Gadamer calls for clarity and transparency of interpretation, and for appropriating and renewing our necessary connection to a cultural tradition. Barthes goes exactly the opposite way. He says there is no clarity of interpretation. That's one of the most dangerous myths of all. Believing that one has arrived at the final and only interpretation is, on this view, the most ideological form of self-deception. What he's done then with the semiotic breakthrough is undermine the presuppositions of Marxist and structuralist culture critique. Structuralism thinks that it's discerning the ultimate algebra inside whatever it investigates and Marxism believes that it is truly unmasking bourgeois ideology to get to the reality of class conflict and exploitation.

Barthes' point is that none of these activities are real. They're just substituting one myth for another. You can't get beyond it.

In the concluding essay *Myth Today*, Barthes calls myth a theft of language because it depoliticizes language. To extend the argument through the later example of *Rambo*, a first viewing may not reveal that it is an apology for American interventionism. It's an apology for American foreign policy which has been for the most part a failure at least with regard to Vietnam. The aim is politicized speech that reveals the agenda behind such constructions. Earlier in his career, he thought repoliticization could reach substantial truth. Later on what it turns out is that this mythic demythologizing is in fact the construction of a left-wing myth.

The demythologizer thus becomes a remythologizer, and the critic becomes a poet, a creative artist. The critic relates to the artwork as the artist relates to nature. In Plato's example in the *Republic*, an artist looks at a bed and paints it. There are three levels of reality. There is the Form of the bed. We have the bed down here and then we have the artistic reconstruction of it. Barthes wants to add a new level to that. We have the critical reconstruction of the artist's text. It can be a painting, it can be a literary work, it can be anything but he is just as free in how he interprets it. Now we have a new domain for the artist to work in. Previously artists have been describing the physical world, the social world. It is now possible for a new sort of critical art to choose as its domain the world of artistic creation itself. Criticism becomes a kind of meta-art.

Then we get the completely free play of the text. He seeks to undermine the authority of the author.

He describes this as the “death of the author.” The author has been abolished and the reason why he wants to abolish the author and abolish authority is because that's what gives the critic completely free play within the domain of the text. Suppose a critic interprets a poem or play and the author replies: “That is not what I meant.” Barthes and this kind of post-structuralist or semiotic critic reply: “So what? The text is free. What you think it means does not determine its meaning for me. You cannot legislate my reading. The contingent historical fact that you did not intend that meaning is not my problem.” The text is all that matters. Intentionality and authority are eliminated, and the reader imposes an interpretation upon it.

He can be said to have liberated the connection between the signifier and the thing signified. He says you could have it signify whatever you want. You take a text, you take a sign and whatever signification you want to attach to it that's perfectly satisfactory. Do not be constrained by any externalities. Retreat back into your own aesthetic judgment, to your own aesthetic experience and the world is completely yours. It's completely the domain of pleasure and your own freedom.

His eventual conclusion is that every limitation on human freedom is ultimately a myth. Clarity, apparently enabling mimesis, is one of the most dangerous myths, since signs, discourse and communication are neither clear nor obscure. Yet obscurity should not become another myth. Barthes does not want to move to either extreme or generalize about the matter. He has no satisfactory resolution.

He's caught between a rock and a hard place. Towards the end of his essay *Myth Today*, he goes to great lengths to try and convince us that right-wing politics is more essentially and closely caught up with myths than left-wing politics. Yet the attempt appears to be made in bad faith: it so evidently minimizes the mythic element of

left-wing politics that it appears to be an ironic, critical construction of a new meta-myth supporting projects he likes. He has decided to read the domain of mythology as if it particularly pertained to people and tendencies that he disapproves of. Of course, when you go back and read between the lines, he undermines the entire proposition that we can demythologize the world. There is no substantial reality.

He retreats into subjectivity. This is why the position can be described as a Cartesian aesthetics. The focus is the ego, but instead of seeking the mathematical structure of the world, it seeks to maximize pleasure in the text. Barthes comes close to saying this explicitly. Near the end of *Myth Today*, he writes: “Even here, in these *Mythologies*, I have used some trickery: finding it painful constantly to work on the evaporation of reality, I have started to make it excessively dense, and to discover in it a surprising compactness, which I savoured with delight.” The justification for this critical activity is not that it truly represents the world, since, on this account, the world cannot be truly represented.

The justification for it is that he really savors it with delight. In other words, this is the triumph of the pleasure principle over the reality principle. There are two possible directions in this domain of postmodern, post-structuralist weightlessness. We can move towards the will to power or we can move towards the will to pleasure. Foucault chooses the first road. He moves towards the will to power and towards political activity. Barthes moves away from political power towards pleasure. In moving towards pleasure, he withdraws into a sort of aesthetic quietism in which you could have political activity as a sort of hobby, but you can't quite take it with the grim and determined seriousness of Foucault. He's involved too much in absorbing the pleasures of the text. He's become an intellectual aesthete. Pleasure is the only justification for any intellectual activity because it can't mimic the world. All of human life is potentially the domain of freedom, creativity, which is to say art.

The transformation of life into art is one of the most powerful and worthwhile readings of Nietzsche. In a way, this is all an homage to Nietzsche. There is no distinction between appearance and reality; ultimately, there is only an infinite series of masks and illusions. What could be more Nietzschean and perspectival? What could be more ironic and at the same time gratify one's will to power? Particularly if the will to power has been transformed into the ego, into simple interiority. The will to power becomes the will to pleasure. It's worth comparing Barthes's work to the work of some of the other structuralists or Marxists to see the uniqueness of his sort of position and also to see how in some respects it all simultaneously expresses a general collective tendency in particularly French intellectual high culture.

One of his contemporaries, Althusser, tried to unify Marxism and structuralism. In some ways this is the last of the modernist paradigms. We get these giant deterministic systems and then try and show that they both operate simultaneously and are both part of some larger metasystem. Barthes knew Althusser and regarded this as the worst possible approach. The reason we are giving up structuralism, the reason we are giving up Marxism is because these large deterministic systems first of all inhibit and as a matter of fact prohibit human freedom. Freedom turns out to be an illusion. You get these giant deterministic systems. In addition to that, they all entail totalizing discourses, huge metanarratives, big picture stories which no one believes in anymore.

According to Barthes, those at the forefront of high culture can no longer take seriously the idea that everything has a secret algebra hidden inside it.

It's the job of structuralists to find the secret algebra hidden in mathematics, hidden in crystals, hidden in biological life forms, hidden in literary constructs and also hidden in anthropology. He rejects the idea of a secret algebra hidden in everything, treating it as a myth invented to legitimize structuralist discourse. That project has run its course. Criticism and negation have become so powerful that they negate their own foundations.

They negate the structures that made criticism and negation possible. An analogy is the self-destroying machine created by Jean Tinguely, an artist associated with Neo-Dada: when activated, it set about destroying itself. The machine is activated, criticizes everything around it, and then begins to criticize itself. This process of destruction, this Nietzschean philosophizing with a hammer, becomes a sort of intellectual vandalism. Nothing is left except the ego.

There isn't even a complete self because when we break down the structures of communication, the structures of knowledge, and the structures of linguistic interaction which give us some real hold to the external world, it ultimately means that we're moving in the direction of solipsism. That means that there's just me and my world and whatever I might happen to wish to do with it. The advantage of this is that it allows us completely free play within the domain of our experience and within the domain of our mental activity. The disadvantage of it is that it is a hopeless attempt to avoid the external world. The problem is that the external world is still there whether you like it or not. As Dr. Johnson said: “I refute it thus.” There it is. Barthes thinks that this is another ideological construct and that the external world is socially constructed, linguistically constructed, and we could simply unconstruct it if it gets in our way. It's amazing the degree of egoism and wishful thinking that you need to engage in before you can argue a project like this.

He radicalizes one set of presuppositions and takes them as far as possible. The problem is that the snake ultimately ends up eating its own tail and the whole project disappears. This is what we get when we get towards the end of Barthes's life, the last seven or eight years. His work becomes intensely personal and it's not clear at some times whether he's writing a novel or whether he's writing a piece of literary criticism or whether he's writing a series of essays or whether he's writing one essay or a book formally like Nietzsche's *The Gay Science* where it's just a series of vignettes that don't really hold together. He completely gives up on the idea of structure or form. It all begins to break down and this breakdown of literary structure, this breakdown of communicative form is analogous to the breakdown of external reality.

When that direct mooring to the external world is lost, the self becomes contingent, dubious and fragmentary. Wittgenstein's account of language suggests that the self, like language, depends on social relations. If we try to remove ourselves from the external world, we may end up talking to ourselves. It is not certain that this is a problem for Barthes. He appears to find a kind of transcendence here: a way beyond the contingencies and limitations of human life toward another realm. In a sense, he reinvents metaphysics, locating it not outside space and time but within his own consciousness. He dismisses the rest of the world, as if saying: “I shall allow you to exist

if I choose to invent you linguistically. Otherwise, do not interfere with my activity. I wish to be entirely free."

If Shakespeare told him that he was misinterpreting a play, the reply would be: "What does your opinion have to do with my freedom? Leave me alone. I have entirely free play." Barthes is, in this sense, an anti-Daedalus. In Greek mythology, Daedalus found a way to escape the labyrinth. Barthes' reply would be: "Labyrinth? What labyrinth? I live here. We are not trying to get out. There is no outside." This is it. You happen to be locked in your subjectivity and the domain of your universe ends with your fingertips. The idea that there is a way out of this problem that will allow us to find the way the world really is as opposed to the way the world is within the domain of our semiotic system is just the hopeless platonic dream of modernist metaphysics from the time of the ancient Greeks to the time of the moderns up to, say, Lévi-Strauss.

His position is: "This is it. I live here." One must accept the absolute contingency of subjectivity and abandon other standards, such as logical coherence or correspondence with the external world. One moves away from the reality principle toward pleasure, the only thing that could justify intellectual activity. Even that doesn't justify it. There is no justification for intellectual activity.

What could we gesture at besides our own semiotic system? We're locked into that. Semiotic systems are incommensurable and untranslatable. Because they're incommensurable and untranslatable, there is not necessarily a conflict between Freudianism and Marxism. It's just that there's no privileged position from which we can decide that Freudianism as opposed to Marxism is the true semiotic system which discloses ultimate reality. There's just no such thing. There's an infinite number of perspectives.

This leads to a world in which everyone is profoundly lonely, with societies of atomized individuals speaking their own languages and living in their own worlds. The mind turns inward, away from the forces that hold language, society and culture together. This negative critique nevertheless finds tactical uses in claiming that demythologizing is possible, or at least occasionally useful, for advancing left-wing politics. The artist or critic becomes a political dilettante. Barthes pursues politics occasionally because he finds it pleasurable. The sort of politics he likes to pursue is the politics which increases and extends his own pleasure. The reason why he does it, well, at the fundamental level is because he finds it pleasurable. Pleasure is the only thing that one can refer to. For tactical reasons, it may be useful not to suggest that. It may be worthwhile to write a book suggesting that left-wing myths are very different from right-wing myths and they're not nearly so mythological somehow. What he's doing is just creating a meta-myth, a new myth.

That means that we have a new order of poetry called literary criticism. We have a new order of critic who is now the ultimate poet because where the poets had to accept contingency and had to accept the simple determination of the external world, the critic is not bound by nature. The critic is trying to undermine nature. The critic flees nature into the realm of the text. This is why Barthes can be called an anti-Daedalus, the figure who says: "Stop asking how to leave the labyrinth. Stop asking how to find substantial reality independent of your semiotic mythologizing."

In fact, it's masks all the way down. For that reason, he adopts a sort of ironic stance because what is there left for the critic to do? Certainly he can't communicate any reality about a text to anybody else because it won't be any more real than whatever they already believe or whatever they already think. The only thing he can do is indulge himself, is gratify his desire for pleasure by increasing the domain of his freedom so that it covers all communicative behavior, so that it covers the whole set of signs. Nature, for example, is one of our signs for external coercion, the externality of things. We can treat that as a myth as well. The whole world then becomes a human domain constructed by human beings in society and constructed by human beings in language.

It is Cartesianism raised to a social collective level based not upon physics but upon aesthetics. Descartes is such a great thinker that French culture has never been able to get out from under the shadow of Descartes. They all have a problem with either accepting their own selfhood or demonstrating the reality of the external world. It easily slips off into solipsism if you start your philosophical investigations from the inside. It's going to be so hard to make that jump to outside stuff. The external world may be there, but then again it may not. The result is that the demystifier, here Barthes, is also a remystifier, and the critic is an artist.

This is a position of extreme solitude, a sort of Epicurean withdrawal into the safety and sanctity and security of the soul. The result is that we have an ironic meta-myth. He intends to communicate to us the fact that there's really nothing to communicate about these texts except the fact that they are totally free and open and that there's no authority which you can refer to as coercing or limiting your interpretation. In constructing this Cartesian aesthetics, Barthes makes readers little gods and gives them omnipotence over an infinite domain called the literary text.